# Blessing or a Curse

*The law can save no one — it can only curse those who fail to keep it perfectly. God has always justified sinners as He justified Abraham: by faith alone. Christ became a curse in our place so the blessing of Abraham and the promised Spirit come by faith.*

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# Where this study fits

*Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted*

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **01** 1:1–5<br>The Ground of Liberty | **02** 1:6–10<br>The One True Gospel | **03** 1:11–17<br>Paul's Independent Revelation | **04** 1:18–2:10<br>Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches |
| **05** 2:11–21<br>Peter Goes Back to School | **06** 3:1–5<br>Under a Spell | **07** 3:6–14<br>Blessing or a Curse | **08** 3:15–29<br>The Superiority of the Promise to the Law |
| **09** 4:1–11<br>When I Became a Man | **10** 4:12–20<br>A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove | **11** 4:21–31<br>Paul's Old Testament Story | **12** 5:1–12<br>Taking a Stand in Liberty |
| **13** 5:13–26<br>Walk in the Spirit | **14** 6:1–5<br>Brothers and Burdens | **15** 6:6–10<br>Sowing and Reaping | **16** 6:11–18<br>Teaching the Truth |

# Faith, its substitute, and its solution

*Galatians 3:6–14 · The commentary's outline*

### I. The Study of Faith · vv.6–9

- Foundation — Abraham believed God (v.6)
- Fellowship — only those of faith are Abraham's sons (v.7)
- Fruit — the nations blessed by faith (vv.8–9)

### II. The Substitute for Faith · vv.10–12

- Fabrication — a curse is tied to the law (v.10a)
- Obstruction — the law itself says the just live by faith (vv.11–12)
- Compensation — everyone is under the curse (v.10b)

### III. The Solution of Faith · vv.13–14

- Christ became a curse for us (v.13)
- Christ bestowed the blessing — and the promised Spirit (v.14)

# Abraham: the pattern for justification

*Galatians 3:6–9 · Outline I — The study of faith*

**A** **Foundation · v.6**

**ἐπίστευσεν · ἐλογίσθη**
Abraham believed; righteousness was credited to his account — not earned

**B** **Fellowship · v.7**

**υἱοί**
Only those of faith are sons of Abraham — whatever the family tree says

**C** **Fruit · vv.8–9**

**προευηγγελίσατο**
The gospel preached to Abraham beforehand: “In you all the nations shall be blessed” (Gen 12:3)

Then and now, God justifies the same way: by faith alone, apart from works.

# Why the law can only curse

*Galatians 3:10–12 · Outline II — The substitute for faith*

| A curse is attached | Keep all of it? | No one does | The law's own witness |
|---|---|---|---|
| **κατάραν**<br>“Cursed is everyone who does not continue in all things” (Deut 27:26)<br>*v.10* | “The man who does them shall live by them” (Lev 18:5)<br>*v.12* | The weakness was in the people, not the law (Heb 8:7–8)<br>*v.10* | “The just shall live by faith” (Hab 2:4)<br>*v.11* |

Everyone who does not keep the whole law is cursed — and no one has kept it. We are all under the curse.

# “The just shall live by faith” — three times

*Habakkuk 2:4 in the New Testament · Outline II.B*

### Romans 1:17

- Tells who the just are

### Galatians 3:11

- Tells how the just shall live
- δίκαιος · ζήσεται — the believer's ongoing life of faith

### Hebrews 10:38

- Explains what “by faith” means — introducing Hebrews 11

Even under the law, the law itself testified that righteousness comes by faith.

# Christ became a curse for us

*Galatians 3:13–14 · Outline III — The solution of faith*

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **v.13a** | “Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the law” | **ἐξηγόρασεν**<br>bought out of the slave market |
| **v.13b** | “having become a curse for us” | **γενόμενος**<br>He became the curse in our place |
| **vv.10, 13** | Deut 27:26 and Deut 21:23 — the same word binds them | **ἐπικατάρατος**<br>“cursed” — law's curse, Christ's curse |
| **v.14a** | “that the blessing of Abraham might come upon the Gentiles” | justification by faith, apart from law |
| **v.14b** | “that we might receive the promise of the Spirit through faith” | **ἐπαγγελίαν**<br>received by faith, not works |

# Discuss and apply

*Galatians 3:6–14 · from the study's posted questions and applications*

## Discuss

1. What does it mean that righteousness was “accounted” to Abraham (v.6)? How does that differ from earning it?

2. In what sense did Christ “become a curse” for us (v.13), and what does “redeemed” (ἐξαγοράζω) add?

## Apply

**Resting in an Imputed Righteousness**
Write down one place you're tempted to “earn” what God has given freely, and replace the striving with a prayer of thanks.

**Refusing to Trade Good News for Bad News**
When you share your faith this week, consciously keep the gospel free of add-on requirements.

**In one line:** The law can only curse; Christ took the curse so the blessing comes by faith.